

Today we turn to our third big question. This question can be introduced by an example.

Suppose that in the year 2069 the surviving members of this Introduction to Philosophy class decided to have an Intro to Philosophy reunion, and all gathered in this room. Suppose that they decided to get a group picture taken.

Now imagine that, via some sort of time travel device, I now have that photo, and show it to you. You might ask: Am I one of those people? Which one am I?

It is very natural to assume that these questions must have determinate answers. There must be some fact of the matter about whether one of the people in the photo is you. And, if one is you, there must be some fact of the matter about which one is you.

Let's suppose that this is true: there must be a fact about whether you survive to be
in this picture, and must be a fact about which of the survivors you are.

Then we can ask a question about these facts:

**The survival
question:** What does it
take for for some
person at some other
time to be you?

To introduce our main answers to the survival question, it will be useful to think about a simple, uncontroversial example of survival.

All of you believe that you will wake up tomorrow in your bed. To put the same point another way, all of you believe that the person now sitting in your seat is the same person as — identical to — the person who will wake up in your bed tomorrow morning.

What do we mean when we say that you are identical to that person?

Here it is important to get clear at the outset on one distinction which, if not attended to, can make these questions more confusing than they have to be.

This is the distinction between **numerical** and **qualitative** identity.

To say that x and y are numerically identical is to say that they are literally the same thing — they are one, not two.

To say that x and y things are qualitatively identical is to say that they are exactly resembling — they have just the same properties.

When we say that you are identical to the person who will get out of your bed tomorrow morning, we are not of course saying that you are qualitatively identical to that person. Their hair will be messed up, and they will be wearing different clothes.

Rather, we mean that you are numerically identical to that person: there is just

one person who is today in this class, and is tomorrow morning in that bed.

But then we can ask the survival question: in virtue of what are you numerically
the same person as the person who will wake up in that bed?



**materialist
survival**

But this is not the only answer to our question. It is a widely held view that we are not simply material beings, but also have immaterial souls.

If one believes in immaterial souls, then it is natural to think
that one's survival is closely linked to the continued
existence of one's immaterial soul.

This suggests an alternative theory of survival. On this view,
the person who wakes up in that bed tomorrow is you
because they are, or have, the same immaterial soul.

A solid red circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the words "soul" and "survival" are written in a white, bold, sans-serif font, stacked vertically.

**soul
survival**

But these are not the only possible views here. One might also hold that you are that person not because of any physical connections, and not because of anything involving immaterial souls, but rather because of **psychological connections** between you and that person.

Which psychological connections? One popular approach focuses on memories. On this view, the thing which makes you the same person as the person who will wake up in that bed tomorrow is your shared memories.

Of course there are plenty of other psychological connections you will have to that person as well. You will have very similar beliefs and desires, and very similar personalities.

Let's call the idea that you are the same person because of
your psychological connections **psychological survival**.

This makes it clear that the soul theory is **radically** different than the psychological theory. After all, one could endorse the psychological theory while denying that there are such things as immaterial souls.

Souls in this sense are not brains. Brains are, of course, material things. Souls are not.

To endorse the soul theory, you have to think that, in addition the various material things we find in the world, there are host of immaterial things.

Consider you yesterday and you right now. What do the psychological and soul theories say explains the fact that you are the same person you were yesterday?

The psychological theory says: you stand in the right psychological connections -- for example, connections of memory.

The soul theory says: you are, or are related in the right way to, a
certain immaterial object.

But there is no obvious reason why these theories should have much to do with each other at all. It seems as though I can stand in memory relations to something even if we are not related to the same immaterial object. Someone who denies the existence of immaterial souls does not have to deny the existence of memories!

And I can be related to the same immaterial object over time even if I don't maintain the right psychological connections. There is no obvious reason why I can't be connected to one and the same soul while experiencing complete amnesia.

How is this theory related to the psychological theory?

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